chief of Samajwadi Party, a regional political party in UP, also in the Opposition, tweeted, 'We have full confidence in the wisdom of our scientists, but none in the BJP's unscientific ways of banging vessels and BJP's unpreparedness to fight the pandemic. We will not take the BJP's political vaccine. Once our government comes to power, we will inoculate people free of cost.'[7] Just to explain how much disruption ludicrous statements like these cause, let me take you through a study in which Dr Shamika Ravi at Brookings Institute was monitoring vaccination rates in various districts in UP. They found that the districts which had the least vaccination uptake were indeed those in which Akhilesh's Samajwadi Party had tremendous influence.[8] Perhaps recognizing the potential negative public health impact of this and its poll consequences in 2022, six months later, his father and founder of Samajwadi Party, Mulayam Singh Yadav, had to publicly take the Covaxin jab to reverse the damage. Following which, Akhilesh too made a U-turn over his earlier remarks and noted that he too would get vaccinated with Covaxin.[9] However, back to his unscientific proclamations, about half a year later when he took to the streets to campaign for poll-bound UP, he confessed that he hadn't taken the second dose of the vaccine since he had had COVID-19 and didn't think it necessary to take the second dose.[10] Similarly, social media was heated up with a fractured debate; the Opposition's ecosystem attacked the government and the ruling BJP on catalysing approvals for the vaccines by discrediting the wisdom of the top scientists who made data-based decisions. The BJP retorted with its party president J.P. Nadda tweeting,

> Time and again we have seen whenever India achieves something commendable—that will further public good—the Congress comes up with wild theories to oppose and ridicule the accomplishments. The more they oppose, the more they are exposed. Latest example is the COVID vaccines. To further their own failed politics and nefarious agendas, Congress and other Opposition leaders are trying to cause panic in the minds of the people. I urge them to do politics on other issues, they should avoid playing with people's previous lives and hard-earned livelihoods.[11]

Other leaders from the BJP and their social media loyalists also defended the government's decision and called out the Opposition leadership for trying to spread fear and vaccine hesitancy. The Opposition's effort to dent